Chapter 1: The island that rented the future

Why the most powerful technology of our time bears the seal of a Caribbean paradise and how the idea of creating the .ia Designation of Origin was born

When I first asked myself the question, I thought the answer would be obvious.

Every day we open dozens of web pages, medical applications, financial assistants, educational tools or news services that end in the same two letters: .ai. We assume that this suffix means Artificial Intelligence. We assume, almost without thinking about it, that behind those two letters there is some type of international technological registry, some institution that verifies that what we are using is really artificial intelligence and that it complies with minimum security rules.

But there is nothing like that.

In 1995, when the Internet geographic codes were distributed, each territory on the planet was assigned two letters: .es for Spain, .fr for France, .de for Germany. Anguilla, a small British overseas territory located in the Caribbean, with just ninety square kilometers and fifteen thousand inhabitants, was randomly assigned the code .ai.

For almost thirty years, that domain hardly interested anyone outside of that island famous for its coral beaches and its tax-free fiscal regime. Until the artificial intelligence fever broke out. Overnight, thousands of companies, laboratories and speculators around the planet began paying millions of dollars to rent addresses ending in '.ai' solely because, in English, they coincided with the fashionable acronyms.

Today, a gigantic part of the new digital economy operates under the flag of a Caribbean island that charges a million-dollar toll for each registration, but does not require a single guarantee from whoever buys the domain. It doesn't matter if behind a .ai website there is a legitimate scientific team, a system that secretly trades in your children's medical data or an automated scam incapable of being accountable to any European judge. As long as you pay the annual fee, you have the same sticker on the door.

What we learned centuries ago at any table

When I discovered how that market really worked, I thought of something much closer and more everyday.

In Europe we have been protecting what enters our home for generations. When you buy a bottle of olive oil, wine or cheese with Denomination of Origin, you do not need to be an agronomist or analyze the product in a laboratory before giving it to your family. That seal on the label tells you three things immediately:

1. It has a proven intrinsic quality, the result of clear production standards.
2. There is traceability, from the origin to your hands.
3. There is someone responsible, subject to real inspections and our laws, who loses the seal if they deceive the consumer.

Imagine for a moment a supermarket where any manufacturer in the world could stamp the words “Denomination of Origin” on a container simply by paying fifty dollars to an office in the Caribbean, without passing a single health check. We would find it intolerable.

Yet that is exactly what we are enabling with technology that already writes contracts, screens resumes, diagnoses illnesses, educates our teenagers, and shapes public opinion. We have filled the Internet with bottles without health control and have let them disguise themselves with the surname of a tropical island.

Two letters that belong to us: .ia

It was then that I noticed a second anomaly, even more striking if possible.

More than six hundred million people in the world—and hundreds of millions of citizens within the European Union—speak languages where this technology is not even abbreviated AI. In Spanish, French, Italian, Portuguese or Romanian, we say Artificial Intelligence (AI).

I searched for the domain .ia on the official Internet map. He didn't belong to any country. It was not rented to any tax haven. It was empty, in a technical limbo, waiting for someone to propose why it should exist.

And there was born the idea that no longer let me sleep peacefully:

What if, instead of using .ia to sell web addresses to the highest bidder, the

European Union claimed and created the .ia domain as the world's first Digital Designation of Origin?

A space on the Internet where having the .ia extension was not a question of a checkbook, but a seal of intrinsic quality: the immediate guarantee for any citizen that this service complies with real standards of transparency, respects human privacy, honestly identifies when you interact with a machine and responds legally in European territory.

From the idea on paper to the gates of Strasbourg

I could have just written an article about it, posted it on social media, gotten a few pats on the back, and watched the idea be forgotten in forty-eight hours.

But in the European Union treaties there is a tool that very few people know about and that even fewer people dare to activate: the European Citizens' Initiative (ECI). It is not a symbolic collection of signatures on a private website. It is an official legislative mechanism: if a group of citizens from at least seven countries manages to get their proposal accepted for processing by the European Commission and gathers one million verified signatures with an identity document, the Government of Europe is obliged by law to respond and open the parliamentary route.

They told me that it was practically impossible for the European Commission to register such a proposal coming from ordinary citizens, without a political party, without a pressure group in Brussels and without large corporations behind it.

They were wrong.

On October 6, 2026, meeting in Strasbourg, the College of Commissioners of the European Union formally approved Decision C(2026) 7098 final, registering our initiative under the official code ECI(2026)000012 and enabling the electronic ballot box where it will be decided whether the .ia domain becomes European law.

This story, which I will publish chapter by chapter in odisea.deft.work, is the true story of how we got here, of how a Denomination of Origin .ia can change our daily lives and how we are going to get those million signatures together.

In the next chapter I will tell you why this whole trip began looking towards a sunken ship two thousand years ago in the Aegean Sea, and how seven strangers

from seven different countries came together to turn the first key to Brussels.

Be part of this story

1. Step 1 — Receive Chapter 2: Subscribe below to receive the next chapter as soon as it is published and direct notification the day the official ballot box opens.

2. Step 2 — Your firm builds the .ia domain: In Spain and in the EU, officially supporting a European Citizens' Initiative takes less than a minute (it only requires your Name and ID on the official platform of the European Commission: https://eci.ec.europa.eu/068/public).